

I. The Challenge: Addressing Structural Barriers in Tax Discovery

Government tax websites provide critical services, yet research and user interviews revealed that many residents struggle to pay their taxes because they cannot locate the correct pages. Our research indicated that the existing site structure is not intuitive enough for users to navigate successfully, often leading to frustration and a reliance on external help.

II. The Strategy: Navigation as the Core Solution

I led the design of **AskBC**, a conversational AI prototype created to navigate users directly to the information and payment flows they need. Rather than a static search bar, the chatbot acts as a guided search tool that bridges the gap between fragmented government resources and the end user.

III. The Mechanism: Data-Driven Conversation Flows

The primary goal was to create a customized tax payment flow based on individual user input. I designed the conversation logic to move users through a specific sequence of information-gathering steps.

- **Intentional Data Collection:** The flow prompts users for key details—such as residency status, age, and property ownership—to filter out irrelevant information.
- **Customized Outcomes:** By processing this information, the chatbot navigates the user to a personalized guide, ensuring they reach the correct destination for their specific tax liability.
- **Structural Impact:** This design replaced complex, multi-level menu navigation with a direct, conversational path, significantly reducing the cognitive effort required to find specific tax credits.

Figure 3.1 – Customized Tax information

IV. Refining the Experience: Establishing Trust

While the personalized navigation was our primary focus, user interviews highlighted a critical concern regarding data security. Participants were hesitant to share the personal details required for the customized flow without clear assurances of privacy.

- **The Design Intervention:** I introduced a **Confidentiality Checkbox** at the start of the data-collection phase.
- **The Language:** I authored a concise, transparent disclaimer confirming that user information remains confidential and is used solely to personalize the navigation.
- **The Result:** This simple addition allowed users to feel secure in providing the data necessary to unlock the customized navigation experience.

Figure 4.1 – Confidentiality Checkbox

V. Impact and Results

By prioritizing a guided, user-centric navigation flow, the prototype achieved measurable improvements in usability testing:

- **Task Success:** Task completion rates rose from 50% to 75%.
- **Time Efficiency:** Average time-to-information dropped from 5 minutes to 2 minutes.
- **Usability:** Users reported a higher sense of confidence when navigated to pages tailored to their specific status.